

Afternoon Discoveries: October 2, 2026

Nonfiction, Memoir, Essays, & Narrative Journalism



AMONG THE LETTERS

OCT 02, 2026



Nonfiction, Memoir, Essays, & Narrative Journalism

*Some essays build a life around an object small enough to hold in one hand,
others get their scale by staying with a place long enough for the ordinary
surface to change.*

That range is part of what makes Friday's shelf interesting... the pressure of attention; the point where experience becomes more precise because somebody stayed with it long enough to notice what was really there.

All links in today's edition were checked against the linked publication, publisher, or literary organization page on October 2, 2026.

Featured Discovery

Hockey Dads and Hockey Sons - Nick Paumgarten

After a father coaches his son the son becomes a father and finds himself standing behind another hockey bench.

Nick Paumgarten begins with childhood memories of skating in New York and gradually turns them into something much larger about inheritance. His father became Coach P. Paumgarten later became the father driving to early games, watching every shift, offering advice, expecting too much, and discovering how easily love can become tangled with ambition.

The piece is funny about the absurdity of youth sports without pretending the emotions around them are absurd. A child's game can be trivial and still become one of the places where a parent and child learn how to disappoint, forgive, admire, and misunderstand one another.

Read "Hockey Dads and Hockey Sons" in The New Yorker

The Discovery Desk

I Lost Myself When I Lost Hong Kong - Tiffany Huang

Tiffany Huang looks back on her final night in Hong Kong, a chance meeting with another writer, and the years that followed after she moved away. The encounter itself is brief. What gives the essay its weight is what happens afterward, when memory keeps returning to the city and to a life that can no longer be resumed exactly as it was.

The piece is especially good on the difference between making a decision and emotionally arriving at it. Huang can explain why she left, and that explanation does not prevent regret, nostalgia, or the stubborn feeling that another version of her life remained behind.

Read “I Lost Myself When I Lost Hong Kong” at [Electric Literature](#)

A Night Living in Penn Station - Anand Giridharadas

Anand Giridharadas spends an overnight shift with Lisette Lojo and the Bowery Residents’ Committee team working in and around Penn Station.

The reporting stays close to the actual work of outreach by using familiar faces, repeated conversations, shelter options that may or may not fit the person being offered them, and the patience required when accepting help cannot simply be ordered into existence.

That attention makes the piece more useful than a story built around a single dramatic rescue. The work happens through accumulation, trust

matters, details matter, and a conversation that appears to go nowhere can still change what becomes possible the next time two people meet.

[Read "A Night Living in Penn Station" in The New Yorker](#)

Flowers Are Not Safe - Krista Raspor

A garment fitter adds flowers to something Krista Raspor has spent much of her life trying not to make visible.

Raspor has worn compression garments since childhood because of a rare vascular disorder. In this concise essay, a floral band on a new garment becomes a surprisingly difficult invitation to be seen. The fitter regards the embellishment as pretty, but Raspor understands attention very differently.

[Read "Flowers Are Not Safe" at Brevity](#)

The Ill Well - David Daniel Riedel

A sick cow wanders through a Wyoming winter while a family waits to see whether the calf she is carrying will survive.

David Daniel Riedel begins with an animal behaving strangely and gradually reveals that the problem is much larger than one cow. The family's well water has always been called "strong water." Its smell and taste are familiar enough to have become part of ordinary life.

Only after the cow and her calf die does laboratory testing give that familiarity a different meaning.

[Read "The Ill Well" at Brevity](#)

Thank you for spending some time with this afternoon's edition.

Below this point are six more works of memoir, personal essay, and narrative journalism, three pieces about the craft and architecture of nonfiction, and three special recommendations from the back shelf.

✓ **Subscribed**

Special Recommendations can be found near the bottom of the article.

More From the Discovery Desk

The Work - Katherine Cusumano

Professional wrestling is scripted, but very little about the labour required to perform it is fake.

Katherine Cusumano spent a year following independent wrestlers in the Pacific Northwest, including an emerging performer preparing for opportunities beyond the regional circuit and a veteran whose body carries decades of the work. The reporting moves backstage, into training rooms, small venues, rehearsals, injuries, travel, and the strange vocabulary wrestlers use to separate performance from reality while constantly mixing the two.

What makes the piece unusually interesting is that wrestling becomes a way of thinking about narrative itself. Outcomes may be planned, but

the bodies are real, the ambition is real, and a convincing performance still depends on making an audience believe that each movement means something.

[Read "The Work" at The Believer](#)

A Place Among the Fiddlers - David Alm

Every August musicians gather in Galax Virginia for the Old Fiddler's Convention. David Alm went there with instruments of his own.

His Longreads feature moves through campsites, rain, mud, competitions, late-night jams, family traditions, bluegrass, old-time music, and people who have been returning to the same fairgrounds for decades. Alm is reporting on the gathering, but he is also participating in it, which gives the piece a useful tension between observer and newcomer.

[Read "A Place Among the Fiddlers" at Longreads](#)

Behind the Castle Walls - Bob Chapek with Don Yaeger

Bob Chapek spent nearly three decades at Disney before becoming its chief executive in 2020, just as the pandemic was about to shut down large parts of the company's business.

His new memoir traces that longer career and then turns toward the much more public period at the top. Chapek presents his own account of the decisions, conflicts, criticism, leadership transition, and eventual ousting that defined his tenure as CEO.

This is one participant's attempt to explain the institution from inside it and to shape how his own role in a turbulent period is remembered.

[Read about *Behind the Castle Walls* at Simon & Schuster](#)

Somebody Is Walking on Your Grave - Mariana Enriquez, translated by Megan McDowell

Mariana Enriquez likes cemeteries enough to keep travelling toward them.

In this collection graveyards in Paris, London, Prague, Genoa, Memphis, and elsewhere become points of entry into history, ritual, architecture, folklore, obsession, and the stories people build around the dead.

The form moves between travel writing, memoir, essay, history, and journalism to show how a cemetery can be public space, archive, tourist destination, sacred ground, neglected land, family memory, and a reminder that every city has another city underneath it.

[Read about *Somebody Is Walking on Your Grave* at Granta](#)

Oh, How Lucky We Are - Beryl Gilothwest

Ossabaw Island was not simply a beautiful place in Sandy West's life, it became the problem around which much of that life was organized.

Her grandson, Beryl Gilothwest, writes about West's decades-long relationship with the undeveloped barrier island off Georgia's coast; growing up there, opening it to artists and thinkers, fighting for its preservation, and eventually confronting the fact that protecting the place might require surrendering control over it.

The essay moves between family memory and environmental history without separating them neatly. Gilothwest knew West first as his grandmother. The reader gradually comes to understand the larger public consequences of the choices she was making around him.

Read “Oh, How Lucky We Are” at [The Bitter Southerner](#)

Never Fall in Love With a Man Who Treats Your Pyrex Like Shit - Kellie Kreiss

A Pyrex dish remains after the relationship has mostly left the apartment.

Kellie Kreiss begins with the ordinary debris of a breakup showing a darkened home, possessions being moved in stages, food in the refrigerator, and a note still taped to a lid. The essay keeps returning to small domestic evidence rather than trying to summarize the whole relationship from above.

The Pyrex is funny, specific, and a little ridiculous, but the treatment of an object can become shorthand for a much larger accumulation of disregard. By the time the dish matters the reader understands that it was never only about the dish.

Read “Never Fall in Love With a Man Who Treats Your Pyrex Like Shit” at [Brevity](#)

Beyond the First Shelf

Hummingbird: How the Way I Write Shaped My Memoir - Judy Sandler

Judy Sandler describes her memoir *What Kind of Mother: A Reckoning* as a hummingbird.

The comparison comes from form. Her book is built from short and quick chapters, many capable of standing alone as flash essays. Sandler explains that the structure grew from the way memory actually arrived for her. It was not as an orderly film running from beginning to end, but as charged images and moments selected by emotion and meaning.

It is a useful craft reminder because form is often discussed as something imposed after the material exists. Sandler's experience suggests the opposite possibility. The way a person remembers may already be telling the writer what shape the book wants.

Read "Hummingbird: How the Way I Write Shaped My Memoir" at The Brevity Blog

Writing in First Person? Dial Up the Charisma - Amy L. Bernstein

First person sounds simple because everyone already knows how to say "I." Writing an interesting "I" is another matter.

Amy L. Bernstein looks at several problems that can flatten first-person prose, including repetitive sentence construction and a narrator who reports experience without becoming a compelling presence on the page. Her examples are aimed at both memoir and fiction, which is useful because the underlying problem is the same; proximity alone does not create voice.

Read "Writing in First Person? Dial Up the Charisma" at The Brevity Blog

Revision Can be the Best Part of Writing - Dinty W. Moore

Finishing a draft and finishing a book are not the same event.

Dinty W. Moore begins with the discouraging part of revision... the realization that reaching the last sentence may only mean the next stage of work has begun. However, his argument is that this stage can become one of the most enjoyable parts of writing once the writer stops treating revision as punishment for getting the first draft wrong.

Moore encourages writers to think of words more like clay than stone. Once the material exists revision becomes the opportunity to discover what forms were hidden inside it.

Read "Revision Can be the Best Part of Writing" at The Brevity Blog

Special Recommendations

Shooting an Elephant - George Orwell

An imperial police officer is summoned because an elephant has broken loose in Burma.

By the time he finds the animal, the immediate danger appears to have passed. A large crowd has gathered behind him though, and the officer discovers that carrying a rifle has created an expectation he no longer feels free to ignore.

George Orwell turns that moment into an essay about power that works in two directions. The officer possesses the formal authority of empire yet his performance of that authority increasingly traps him. The crowd is supposedly subject to his power while also determining what he feels compelled to do next.

Orwell's years serving in the colonial police in Burma informed the essay which was first published in *New Writing* in 1936. Questions remain around how literally autobiographical the central incident should be read, but the essay's examination of imperial power and performance has long outlived that uncertainty.

Read "Shooting an Elephant" at The Orwell Foundation

The Pain Scale - Eula Biss

A numerical scale promises that pain can be translated into something orderly.

Eula Biss takes that promise seriously enough to test it. Her lyric essay moves through the familiar zero-to-ten medical scale while bringing in other systems of measurement, including wind, mathematics, language, family conversation, and the difficulty of assigning a number to an experience that refuses to become objective.

The form is part of the inquiry, numbering the sections gives the reader a structure while repeatedly showing how unstable the structure

becomes when applied to a body.

The essay originally appeared in *Seneca Review* and was later collected in *The Best Creative Nonfiction, Volume 1*. A digitized version is available through Duquesne University's Creative Nonfiction archive.

Read "The Pain Scale" in the Creative Nonfiction archive

The Poison That Tastes Like Home - Souvankham Thammavongsa

Food can carry affection long after a relationship has become difficult to name.

Souvankham Thammavongsa writes about returning to her mother after years of distance following the death of her brother. Her mother's cooking becomes one of the languages still available between them, inseparable from everything complicated that came before.

Home can be something a person leaves for good reasons and still tastes everywhere else. Love can be sustaining without becoming uncomplicated, and grief can bring people back into a room without resolving why they left it.

Read "The Poison That Tastes Like Home" at Harper's Magazine

Thank you for spending part of your day among the letters with us.

Today's shelf begins on an ice rink and ends at a kitchen table. In between are train-station corridors, a damaged tooth, a garment meant to compress a body, wrestling rings, fiddles in the mud, corporate memory, cemeteries,

*houses, and one Pyrex dish that has absorbed far more meaning than
cookware is normally asked to carry.*

*That may be what nonfiction does especially well, it takes the things that were
already there and changes their scale through attention. Nothing has to
become imaginary to become strange, moving, funny, or difficult to forget.*

Take care!

✓ **Subscribed**